THE DESERT WELLSPRING

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PREFACE

The Desert Wellspring is the first adventure to be featured on One Shot Heroes, a podcast where two players are thrust into the unknown for roughly an hour in pursuit of fame, fortune, and survival.

First and foremost, I'd like to thank you for being a supporter! We're very excited to bring this show to you and we hope you enjoy this behind-the-scenes view of the adventure. We've written it in such a way that it is a complete module that you can also run at your own table. If you find it too short, simply sprinkle in a few extra rooms, encounters, or complications.

INTRODUCTION

The One-Shot Heroes Podcast opens with a bit of flavor to set the scene.

> In the deserts of Anauroch, far from the pleasures of civilization, an incident has caused two travelers to become lost in a sea of endless sand for days. With their water supply running dry, the situation begins to slide from concerning, to desperate. Will they find a way to survive one of the harshest deserts in Faerun? Or will they end up as a meal for the vultures hovering overhead. This, and more, on today's One-Shot Heroes.

From here, the adventure begins.

HIDDEN INFORMATION

Throughout the scenario the DM will be handing players hidden information for them to communicate, or not communicate, as they see fit. Handouts can be found in Appendix A at the back of this module if you would like to do the same at your table. Otherwise, feel free to share the knowledge openly.

Written by Anthony Gill.

Podcast Episode Players: Sarah M. and Ben C.

SPRING

CREDITS

Podcast Episode Guest Stars: Adam S. as Ankohep and
Steve M. as the Desert Tortoise

Special thanks to the Potomac RPG Crew

Module styling: Advanced GM Binder Styling Reference by Raspilicious.

Cover art: Desert Dreams 3 by Rajesh Misra.

PART 1

Anaurouch Desert

Lost in the Desert

AREA 1 - SURROUNDED BY SAND

The adventure begins with the players lost in the desert.

> You attempted to camp in a ruined village, but fleeing into the night seemed like a better option as slithering movement and snake-like hissing surrounded you from all sides. It is now the afternoon in the Desert of Anauroch (ah-NOR-ach) and you can clearly see that there is nothing but sand in all directions. To make matter's worse, you've left behind some of your gear. Most importantly, your last full waterskin. A ring of mountain peaks in the distance hide the promise of some kind of shelter, but they are several days of travel away and the heat is starting to intensify. One thing is crystal clear - you must find water soon, or you may not survive long enough to see the next sunrise. And with that, your adventure begins.

Allow the players to be directionless for a moment. After each question or action, describe how hot they are beginning to feel

- Sweat is beginning to roll down your forehead.
- Your feet are beginning to bake in your shoes.
- You're beginning to feel a little light-headed
- The desert air begins to shimmer before your eyes.

Dressing for survival or other preventative measures can help quell heat-related symptoms for the time being.

Looking around. If either player succeeds on a Perception DC 10 check, the player with the highest success will faintly notice something too square to be a boulder. It is perhaps a small structure of some kind (The Desert Shrine - Area 3) If both fail explain they see nothing except for dunes that rise and fall in all directions; one of them particularly large. (Area 2)

Identifying Landmarks. A History DC 14 check will reveal the following:

> THE SCIMITAR SPIRES
>
> The three peaks in the distance might be the Scimitar Spires. If so, the Black Road crosses near them. The party may be able to find a caravan of Zhentarim merchants or some nomadic Bedine, who are often generous and hospitable.

Dressing for Survival. A Survival DC 12 check will allow a player to adjust the party's clothing to be more suitable to desert travel, giving them advantage to Constitution saving throws related to heat. (100 XP)

Navigating the Desert. A Survival DC 12 will guide a player instinctively towards a particular dune that may grant a better view. (Area 2)

The players can set a course towards the dune, the fountain, or simply wander aimlessly. If they wander aimlessly, they must make a Constitution DC 10 saving throw or gain 1 level of exhaustion. (If the party has dressed for survival the roll may be made with advantage.) Then reveal area 3.

If the party considers a more distant objective, the oppressive heat should make it clear that is impractical.

AREA 2 - THE Top OF THE DUNE

> From the top of the largest dune, you continue to see an infinite expanse of desert. From this vantage point, however, you do notice a small structure or statue of some kind to your east. It appears to offer the only shade for miles.

At the top of the dune, require the party make a Constitution DC 10 saving throw from the heat or gain 1 level of exhaustion. If the party has dressed for survival, the roll may be made with advantage.

PART 2

The Desert Shrine

AREA 3 - THE DESERT SHRINE

As the party approaches the shrine, they will be able to make out some detail at a distance:

> The structure starts to come into view. It appears to be a small square structure made of desert stone, perhaps no larger than twenty feet on each side and a single story high. In front of it appears to be a fountain.

EVENT'. SCORPION SURPRISE

Secretly reveal to one player (spotter) that the other has a scorpion on their back (victim). If the spotter attacks the scorpion and misses, the attack must be re-rolled against the victim instead. The spotter may attempt to remove the scorpion using a Wisdom (Animal Handling) DC 12 check, but a failure grants the scorpion an attack against the spotter. Lastly, the victim may try to shake it loose on a successful Dexterity DC 12 saving throw. If the check fails, the scorpion may make an attack against the victim. Other creative solutions, like using Mage Hand, may be a better option.

PART 3

Shrine Depths

If anything is added to the chest, the runes on the

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When the party arrives, describe the following:

> After several more minutes of travel, you reach the site. The fountain, unfortunately, has been worn by time and is clearly bone dry. Behind it is a simple stone building with an open entryway. A half-pipe gutter leads from the building to the head of the fountain. At one point the gutter likely fed the fountain, but it is now dry as well, transporting only a lone scorpion. Inside the building you can see steps leading into some sort of lower, unlit chamber.

FOUNTAIN

There used to be water in the fountain, but the pulley system in the tomb broke long ago. From the angle of the gutter it is relatively clear that the building used to provide water to the fountain, but has since stopped

Inspecting the fountain will reveal the repeating symbol that appears to be some kind of "Eye and Crown" crest.

If the player is proficient with History or Religion, a successful History DC 14 or Religion DC 14 check will reveal the following:

> THE EYE AND CROWN SYMBOL
>
> The Eye and Crown is the symbol of a god-king named Isset Thul Kaas who ruled this region long ago. This shrine was likely a waypoint for his followers to rest and make an offering to him. Isset Thul Kaas was known for his cruelty and for protecting his property with dangerous traps.

The DM should again impress upon the players how hot it is becoming. Possible suggestions might include:

The temperature has begun to reach its peak. You can feel your skin starting to sizzle.

The air has become thick with an an almost unbearable humidity. The sun is now directly overhead

- Your lips begin to crack painfully from dehydration and your mouth is dry.

If the players linger too long, inflict a sudden spell of disorientation and light-headedness requiring a Constitution DC 10 check or gain a level of exhaustion.

ENTRYWAY

There are no obstructions blocking the path into the structure, though it is dimly lit inside. This is a good time to inventory what each player is holding in their left and right hand. As they descend they holding a sword and shield? A sword and torch? A bow and arrow? Or are both hands free? Proceed to Room 1 of the Shrine Depths.

ROOM 1 - THE OFFERING ROOM

Before the party enters, ask each player to make a Perception check at disadvantage unless they have dark vision or a light source. The roll may not be less than the player's Passive Perception.

> You descent down stone steps into a small 20 by 1 0 foot chamber. Sunlight provides enough illumination to see that this is some sort of offering chamber. A large wooden chest rests in the center of the room on a raised platform and scattered about the floor at irregular positions are the remains of two humanoid warrior statues. The empty gutter running high along the wall connects the fountain outside and chambers deeper in the shrine like plumbing. The walls are lined with extinguished torches in sconces of pure gold.

If either player scored a 13 or greater on Perception, also add:

> You also hear the sound of wind faintly whistling through a crack in the wall beyond the chest.

Visitors to the shrine are able to make offerings to the godking here in exchange for fresh drinking water.

Treasure Chest. The treasure chest is closed It is empty except for dust, a small piece of parchment and a single gold coin left in the corner, perhaps

overlooked by thieves. If a player takes the coin, it will immediately wake Ankohep, who will use his Dreadful Gaze on both characters from his sarcophagus. (See Waking Ankohep)It will also activate the destroyed statues. Their limbs are destroyed so they can do little more than watch, though one will limb will function and attack as a Crawling Claw. Taking the parchment will not wake Ankohep. The parchment reads:

OFFERING CHAMBER PARCHMENT

We gift upon you our possessions, Magnificent God-King Isset Thul Kaas, and praise you for your generosity.

platform beneath the chest will glow affirmatively and a voice will speak:

> May the infinite waters of God-King Kaas refresh you.

Some sort of machine will faintly cranks to life and can be heard from holes where the gutter is fed. Instead of water generously flowing across the gutter, however, only a faint trickle of dirty water dribbles forth.

Mosaic Door. If the players inspect the room or rolled a successful Perception DC 13 check upon entering, they will notice that the rear wall is really a door. Part of the mosaic tile has been broken off to gain purchase on opening the door. It has since sealed shut again, but a successful Dexterity DC 15 check with Thieves Tools or a Strength DC 16 check can pry the door open. If both checks fail or the players continue searching, they'll find a 6" square mosaic tile that slides away to reveal a deep hole in the wall A handle to unlock the secret door is inside. Be sure to make the players sweat a little for it, however.

Torches. Players can take torches from the wall if they need light. Taking any of the ten golden sconces (25 gold each) however, will wake Ankohep and the broken statues.

ROOM 2 - THE TRAPPED CORRIDOR

> Before you is a 70 foot long corridor, about 1 0 feet wide, that ends with an archway to another room. Small holes line the walls, near the floor. Along the floor are pairs of ancient alphabetic letters. In the center of the corridor, crumpled against a wall, lies the remains of a desert bandit.

Reminder: Be sure to check what players are carrying in their hands and identify their light sources, as the corridor no longer offers natural light.

The corridor is obviously trapped The only safe way through is to step on tiles that spell the name of the God-King (Isset Thul Kaas).

The sequence of the tiles are:

- - - - - - - - - - - - -

I S C M T Z M U A K X A S

P X S E P T H V L B A S L

U A K X A s

P X S EP T HV L B A s L

If the players begin to inquire into the origin of the shrine or try to figure out a pattern in the tiles, they may attempt (or re-attempt) the History or Religion check offered in Area 3 - The Desert Shrine.

Triggering the Trap. If a player steps on the wrong letter, the Blade Traps and Scorpion Swarm Trap will trigger and cannot be disabled. Each tile can be disarmed on a Dexterity DC 10 check with Thieves Tools. Failing will trigger the trap.

Blade Traps. Massive scimitar blades whirl with a random cadence at the locations shown on Blade Trap 1 and Blade Trap 2. Any creature that starts their turn on, or moves through, the blade trap must make an Dexterity (Acrobatics) DC 14 saving throw or take 4D6 piercing damage. A successful save dodges all damage and failing by five or less inflicts half damage. At the start of each round the DC for the blade traps changes to DC 10 + ID8 Players may consider waiting for a more opportune time to jump through.

Scorpion Swarm Trap. A swarm of scorpions crawl from the holes along the floor, attacking the players as they wait to jump through the blades. At the end of the rouncL any player in the corridor will take a single attack from a Scorpion. The swarm cannot be defeated and will not leave the corridor.

Falling Unconscious. If a player drops to 0 Hit Points in the corridor, a player may pull their body at half speed and may attempt to get through the blade traps with disadvantage. If damage is received from the blade traps, carrier will take damage as normal and the unconscious player will take a death saving throw failure. If the unconscious player is left behincL the scorpions will ignore the player until he/she regains 1 hit point.

Bandit Corpse. The corpse of a Tiefling bandit (Kairon) is on the grouncL his skeletal face raised with a gaping cry. Players may spend an action round to make an Intelligence (Investigation) DC 10 check to discover his pack has been taken (by Ankohep) but he has a Potion of Greater Healing

in his hand Apparently he died before he could drink it.

ROOM 3 - THE WELLSPRING

> The large, crumbling chamber before you contains a 1 0 x 1 0 [1] well. A pulley system of buckets appears designed to descend into the well, scoop water, and deliver it to the beginning of a gutter system near the ceiling. The well lacks enough water to scoop, however. At the edge of the well is a circular stone pedestal with a spout pointed towards the well. A decomposed body lies not far from the pedestal, next to another corridor that continues eastward.

The chamber is roughly 30 x 30 and has 20 foot ceilings. Along the walls are six unlit torches with golden sconces like Room #1. Taking any of the sconces will wake Ankohep.

Room debris. Part of the ceiling has collapsed, leaving chunks of stone scattered about the floor. While this does not present a challenge to movement, the stone may be useful in Room #5 for adding weight to Ankohep's sarcophagus, should the players think of it.

Pulley System. The pulley system is still in tact. If the party made a donation the chest in Room 1, the pulley system will be rotating as the party enters, and will continue to rotate until dawn; otherwise it will be stationary. There is not much of interest to the system itself. It is strong enough to hold the weight of a medium creature, though it is somewhat useless for climbing as pulling your weight on one rope causes it to spin and descend

Circular Pedestal. This pedestal used to house a Decanter of Endless Water. Each day, Ankohep would rise to activate the Decanter, keeping the well full of crystal clear water. The Decanter now rests at the bottom of the well, beyond Ankohep's reach, and the well has run dry.

The Wellspring. The well is 30' deep and 10 x 10' ide. The walls are rough stone and can be traversed with an Strength (Athletics) DC 10 check. Each point the check falls below 10 will represent falling 2.5 feet. (e.g. rolling a 6 means the player falls 10 feet.) A player can use the pulley system to descend pirate-style with advantage.

At the bottom of the wellspring is a 1' layer of black, tainted water and the skeletal remains of a Dragonborn. (Hiskan) Hiskan stole the Decanter of Endless Water from the pedestal and awakening Ankohep in Room #4. A blow from the mummy sent him tumbling over the ledge to his death and Ankohep has been unable to retrieve the decanter ever since. Eventually, the water was drained by other visitors and the pulley system. His pack contains the Decanter, a flask of oil six magical Arrows +1, and a long bow. The pack also contains rotted rations and other items in a Burglar's Pack. Touching the Decanter of Endless Water will wake Ankohep in Room #4, as it is property of the God-King.

Corpse in Fine Clothes. The skeletal corpse of a human in scraps of fine clothing lies near the pedestal. The corpse is brittle and will turn to dust when touched, as he died while afflicted with Mummy Rot. The corpse's pack has no treasure - it has been claimed by Ankohep. On the floor near the corpse is a discarded journal written in Common. If a player reads the journal, give them the Lord Argavalt Journal handout.

ROOM 4 - ANKOHEP'S CHAMBER

> A short corridor connects to a grand chamber of painted frescos. In the center of the room is a large sarcophagus on a raised platform. In a corner of the room are jars of organs, an old book, an ancient dagger, bandages, and other materials. There are no exits in this room.

The room is 20x40' with a 15' ceiling, stone walls and stone floring.

Ritual Book. The book was used long ago by the God King to transform Ankohep into a mummy and eternal servant. If a player inspects the book, provide the following handout.

> **THE RITUAL BOOK**
>
> The book contains detailed instructions on how to perform a mummification ritual and was likely used to create the mummy. Using a ceremonial dagger, the dark ritual can transform an unconscious or restrained victim into one's thrall, bound for eternity to perform duties by your command.
>
> You're no expert on the subject, but you feel like you might be able to perform the ritual if you really wanted to.

The ritual generally involves chanting, marking the body of the victim, removing the victim's organs, and wrapping the victim. All of the materials needed for the ceremony can be found on the altar, should a player want to go forward with it. The ritual is successful on an Intelligence (Arcana) DC 15 check. If the check fails, the caster takes 8d6 necrotic damage and is inflicted with Mummy Rot at soon as the first cut is abut to break the victim's skin.

Ritual Dagger. The dagger is a Dagger +1. Holding the hilt feels like holding a handful of squirming maggots, but is otherwise normal As normal as a dark ritual dagger might be.

Jars of Organs. There are five jars of organs that formerly belonged to Ankohep: brain, liver, lungs, stomach and intestines. If the players feel so inspirect destroying a jar fakes an action and inflicts 2d6 (7) force damage on Ankohep.

Sarcophagus. The sarcophagus contains Ankohep (Mummy) and small compartment with a jar containing his heart. The compartment is

easily spotted by any creature who inspects the sarcophagus. Destroying the heart inflicts 8d6 (28) force damage and Ankohep will become affected by his own Mummy Rot, eventually causing his death. The bottom of the sarcophagus is actually a pressure plate. If less than 50 lbs of weight rests on the pressure plate, the entrance in room #1 will seal shut. Once the weight requirement is met, the doorway will re-open. The players will be able to hear the door closing and may notice the sudden lack of sunlight. When Ankohep rises from his tomb, no one may leave. The stones in Room #3 can be used to weigh down the pressure plate. (So could a player's body.)

Frescos. Various frescos along the walls tell a story. If a player stops to analyze them, reveal them as the following:

- Merchants and nomads bringing goods to the shrine and drinking water from a fountain while a mummified figure watches over.
- A mummified figure stands holding a chest of treasure towards a wall. A light shines from its necklace, illuminating a wall.
- A mummified figure creeps menacingly behind an unwitting thief.
- A mummified figure holds his arms high and pours water into a hole from a decanter.
- A closed sarcophagas looks out upon an open door to the desert. There is also ancient writing on this mural

The murals pictorialize Ankohep's instructions: Kill intruders, collect treasure, store treasure in the vault, keep the well full, and return to sleep. Below the last mural is some ancient writing. A successful Intelligence (History) DC 13 check will reveal that it says:

"No one shall leave until the guardian rests."

When the players inspect the second fresco, they should notice that in front of it are some scratches along the floor that hint that the wall may slide open. This is the entrance to room #5 and may only be opened if a player is wearing Ankohep's Necklace.

ROOM 5 - TREASURE VAULT

The second fresco in Room 4 is actually secret door to the treasure vault. Standing in front of it while wearing Ankohep's Necklace will cause it to open, as will a Knock spell When the door is openecL read the following:

“A small chamber behind the secret door holds two large coffers brimming with treasure, likely collected over time as offerings from desert travelers”

Each coffer is loaded with treasure, but could be transfered into a backpack given an hour of work.

Coffer 1. The first coffer is brimming with a mix of gold and silver pieces (440 GP) fine silks (7 x 10 GP) boxes of dried herbs (3 x 2 GP*) and religious texts (2 x 10 GP). Hidden inside a false compartment in one of the boxes of dried herbs are 32 diamonds worth 50 GP each, as well as a small map illustrating where the diamonds came from. The grand total is worth 536 GP, not counting the extra 1,600 GP worth of hidden diamonds.

Coffer 2. The other coffer is also generously filled with coin (330 GP) and contains a few ornate weapons (4 x 25 GP plus a Longsword +1), expertly crafted tapestries (10 x 15 GP), and bottles of aged wine. (8 x 20 GP) The grand total is worth 740 GP.

It may be useful to itemize what is in each coffer and let the players debate about who takes what treasure. Especially since one player may have kept the contents of Lord Argavalt's journal a secret and may be willing to generously take the less valuable coffer, knowing that it also contains a box of diamonds.

ABOUT ANKOHEP

Ankohep betrayed Isset Thul Kaas long ago and was cursed to serve for eternity as a mummy. His duties are as follows:

- Watch over the shrine and destroy any thief who takes treasure that belongs to the god-king.
- Periodically rise and collect treasure from the Offering Room and place it within the Treasure Vault.

WAKING ANKOHEP

If a visitor to the shrine touches any treasure belonging to the god-king, including the Decanter of Endless Water, Ankohep will wake. From his sarcophagus Ankohep can see all activity in the shrine. The following events will occur when Ankohep wakes.

- Guardian Statues. Ankohep can activate the two Guardians of Isset Thul Kaas in the Offering Room if it will stop intruders. The statues have long since been destroyed, however, and can only attack as a single Crawling Claw.
- Dreadful All-Seeing Eye. Ankohep will attempt to pry into the mind of all those in the shrine, which feels like a necrotic gaze into one's soul His Dreadful Glare is immediately applied to all living creatures in the shrine, instead of having a direct 60' radius.
- Sense of Dread. If a creature fails the saving throw against his Dreadful All-Seeing Eye , Ankohep is able to gleen basic

facts about the creature: their name, place of origin, intent, etc. This creature will have a general sense of unease while in the shrine and will have disadvantage to resist Ankohep's Dreadful Glare when face-to-face with the mummy. Ankohep will call to the creature by name and intimidate them with his knowledge of their fears.

- Rise from his Grave. Ankohep will leave his sarcophagus after the party has stolen any treasure. The reduction of weight in the sarcophagus will seal the entrance of the shrine. Creatures in Room 3 can hear Ankohep's sarcopagus opening on a successful Wisdom (Perception) DC 18 check. Disadvantage applies if the creature is inside the wellspring.

ANKOHEP'S AMULET

Ankohep wears a golden amulet worth 200 GP emblazoned with the symbol of the god-king. The amulet can be used to open the door to Room 5. If the creature takes the amulet, it must succeed on a Constitution DC 12 saving throw or be cursed with mummy rot.

ANKOHEP'S DEATH

If the players defeat Ankohep, he will turn to dust, leaving only his amulet.

ESCAPING THE SHRINE

The only source of water in this adventure is the Decanter of Endless Water at the bottom of the well, so it's virtually impossible not to wake Ankohep. Once Ankohep leaves his sarcophagus, the entrance to the shrine will seal shut.

Ankohep is extremely dangerous for a small party to take on directly. Torches and a flask of oil from the dragonborn corpse may help, as will his magic arrows. Destroying the five jars on the altar in Room 4 will inflict a total of 10d6 (35) damage, and finding his heart will inflict another 8d6 (28) damage. This should be enough to bring the mummy down if the party is clever enough. Consider dropping hints or triggering Religion checks to suggest there may be other ways to win beyond brute force. A strategic player may also try to occupy Ankohep with a Dodge action while the rest of the party attacks or searches for a weakness.

Once Ankohep is defeated, the party will need to find a creative way to weigh down the trigger in Ankohep's sarcophagus. Options could include:

- Using crumbled stone from Room 3.
- Placing enough equipment or treasure into the sarcophagus to weigh down the pressure plate.
- Placing the body of a dead adventurer into the sarcophagus. (Note: Lord Argavalt and his two companions are too brittle to provide weight and will crumble when moved Except for the dragonborn in the well their goods have been transfered into Room 5 and have no weight to offer.)

Of course, we certainly hope your players don't think that someone needs to be bound/knocked unconscious and turned into a replacement mummy using the ritual book. That would be terrible.

APPENDIX

Player Handouts

THE SCIMITAR SPIRES

The three peaks in the distance might be the Scimitar Spires. If so, the Black Road crosses near them. The party may be able to find a caravan of Zhentarim merchants or some nomadic Bedine, who are often generous and hospitable.

THE EYE AND CROWN SYMBOL

The Eye and Crown is the symbol of a god-king named Isset Thul Kaas who ruled this region long ago. This shrine was likely a waypoint for his followers to rest and make an offering to him. Isset Thul Kaas was known for his cruelty and for protecting his property with dangerous traps.

OFFERING CHAMBER PARCHMENT

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LORD ARGAVALT JOURNAL

The latest entries of the journal explain how he, Lord Argavalt, hired a Tiefling and Dragonborn to loot this shrine. Apparently desert travelers make offerings of treasure at this shrine in exchange for fresh water. Treasure never seems to leave the shrine, so it must be stored somewhere.

The journal makes repeated references to a plain, unassuming box of dried herbs, donated to the shrine by desert traders. Beneath a false bottom in the box hides a fortune in diamonds. Lord Argavalt came to the shrine to find this valuable box.

(Note: As the reader, you are not obligated to read this aloud verbatim. Feel free to summarize.. or omit.. as desired)

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FRESCO INSCRIPTION

"No one shall leave until the guardian rests."